THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER EIGHT

“THE WOMAN IN THE GARAGE”

December 12, 2008 – May 5, 2009
View Park • Surrey • Hollywood • Bel Air

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

FADE IN:

INT. AMC MAGIC JOHNSON THEATRES - AUDITORIUM 9 - BALDWIN HILLS - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, DECEMBER 12, 2008 - 7:30 P.M. PST

Opening night of HALLELUJAH HOLIDAY. The auditorium is less than a third full: a few church groups, some grandmothers, two bored teenagers. On screen, ESTHER SMILLEY as SISTER MARY GRACE, in a habit, sings a gentle carol to a goat named Bartholomew in a snowy barn.

In the back row, alone, in a hoodie: ESTHER (26). She watches herself sing to the goat. Her face shows nothing at all.

A TEENAGE GIRL (15) two rows ahead whispers loudly to her friend.

TEENAGE GIRL
She's so pretty. Why is she always a nun or a princess or a nun princess?

FRIEND
My mom says she's not allowed to be anything else.

Esther closes her eyes.

CUT TO:

THE NEW YORK TIMES - MOVIES - FRIDAY, DECEMBER 12, 2008

Silent Night, Sweet Night, Too-Sweet Night

"Hallelujah Holiday" is wholesome in the way a sugar cube is nutritious. Its star, Esther Smilley, has a voice that could shatter glass and a screen presence that hints at depths this movie is terrified of. Someone should give her a real part before she spends her entire career singing to livestock.

BOX OFFICE MOJO - SUNDAY, DECEMBER 14, 2008

WEEKEND ESTIMATES: "The Day the Earth Stood Still" $30.5M ... #9: "Hallelujah Holiday" $4.1M

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - KITCHEN - VIEW PARK - MORNING

SUPER: MONDAY, DECEMBER 15, 2008 - 8:10 A.M. PST

DESMOND (51) reads the trades at the island. CELESTE (48) makes oatmeal. Esther comes in. Desmond holds up the Box Office Mojo printout.

DESMOND
Four point one million. It's the economy, sweetheart. Nobody's going out. Families are scared.

ESTHER
(quietly)
The New York Times said I should get a real part.

CELESTE
The New York Times doesn't buy tickets in Kansas.

DESMOND
Your audience is families, Esther. Church groups. Grandmothers. They love you. You don't throw that away because one critic in Manhattan wants to see you in something "edgy."

ESTHER
It wasn't one critic. It was a girl in the movie theater. She asked why I'm always a nun.

Desmond sets down the paper and looks at her with the patient smile he's been using since she was six.

DESMOND
Because nuns are safe, baby. And safe is what keeps this family's lights on.

Esther looks at her father. She opens her mouth. Closes it. She takes a banana and leaves the kitchen. Desmond goes back to the trades. Celeste watches the doorway after she's gone.

CUT TO:

VARIETY - TUESDAY, JANUARY 13, 2009

DIVINE TO BE MARVEL'S BLACK WIDOW

Broadway dancer Harmony Divine lands the role of Natasha Romanoff in "Iron Man 2" after Emily Blunt's exit. The former Tony nominee, recovered from a 2005 knee injury, will perform her own fight choreography. She is reportedly dating "Incredible Hulk" star Amond Baker.

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "HARMONY DIVINE IS BLACK WIDOW" (Page 1 of 59)

WarMachineRox (Jan 13, 9:40 AM)
A real dancer playing the Widow. The fights are going to look like ballet that can kill you.

ShellHead1963 (Jan 13, 9:55 AM)
Apology #208: I said "who?" an hour ago. Then I watched her Tony Awards performance on YouTube. Never mind.

NoNerfsPlz (Jan 13, 10:02 AM)
Still no Thor. Branagh's been "seeing everybody" for months. Rumor is they've read 400 actresses.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - CORNELIUS'S STUDY - VIEW PARK - NIGHT

SUPER: SATURDAY, JANUARY 31, 2009 - 10:40 P.M. PST

A small, book-lined room at the back of the house. Playbills on the wall: A RAISIN IN THE SUN (1959), HENRY V - NEW YORK SHAKESPEARE FESTIVAL, CENTRAL PARK (1963), OTHELLO (1971). A Tony Award on a shelf, a little dusty. CORNELIUS SMILLEY (75) sits in a worn leather chair reading by lamplight. A knock.

CORNELIUS
It's open.

Esther enters and closes the door behind her. She holds a folder against her chest like a shield.

ESTHER
Granddaddy. Can I ask you something? And can you promise not to tell Daddy?

Cornelius lowers his book. He's been waiting for this conversation since election night.

CORNELIUS
That depends on the something.

Esther opens the folder and hands him a single page: an audition side. At the top, in Marvel letterhead: "THOR - SCENE 14 - THE BANISHMENT."

Cornelius puts on his reading glasses and reads. His eyebrows rise slowly.

ESTHER
Simone got it for me. An old producer from her sitcom knows the casting director. They're taking self-tapes for two more weeks. The director wants someone who can do the verse. Real verse, like Shakespeare.

(beat)
You played Henry the Fifth in Central Park for Joe Papp when you were twenty-nine. You're the only person I know who can teach me.

Cornelius looks at the page, then at his granddaughter. A long silence.

CORNELIUS
You know whose universe this is. The Bullock boy. The Donohues' grandson.

ESTHER
It's Stan Lee and Jack Kirby's universe. Marc-Anthony just lives in it.

Something flickers in Cornelius's eyes at the way she says the name. Just for a second. He lets it pass.

CORNELIUS
Your father will be furious.

ESTHER
I know.

CORNELIUS
Your mother will cry.

ESTHER
I know.

CORNELIUS
And you want it anyway.

ESTHER
(her voice steady for the first time)
More than anything I've ever wanted in my life.

Cornelius stands up slowly. He crosses to the bookshelf and pulls down a battered, heavily annotated copy of HENRY V. He blows dust off the cover and holds it out to her.

CORNELIUS
Then we start with the breath. Verse doesn't live in the mouth, baby girl. It lives here.

(tapping his own diaphragm)
Every line is a heartbeat. Ten syllables. Da-DUM, da-DUM, da-DUM, da-DUM, da-DUM. A god doesn't rush. A god knows the universe will wait for her to finish her sentence.

Esther takes the book. Her hands are trembling.

ESTHER
You'll help me?

CORNELIUS
(a slow, sad smile)
On election night, I told you not to be a proud old fool like me. The least I can do is help you be the opposite.

CUT TO:

MONTAGE - FEBRUARY 2009: THE WARRIOR IN THE GARAGE

SUPER: FEBRUARY 1 - FEBRUARY 21, 2009

-- CORNELIUS'S STUDY, NIGHT. Esther reads aloud. Cornelius stops her every few words, conducting with a pencil. "Again." "Again." "No. You're asking permission. Gods don't ask."

-- THE SMILLEY GARAGE, 5:30 A.M. Esther, in sweats, swings a fifteen-pound sledgehammer from Home Depot in slow arcs, over and over, sweat pouring. SIMONE (29), in a bathrobe with coffee, sits on a lawn chair timing her with a kitchen timer.

SIMONE
That's two hundred. Your arms are going to fall off.

ESTHER
(gasping, still swinging)
Thor's arms don't fall off.

SIMONE
Thor is fictional.

ESTHER
Not to me.

-- A BOXING GYM ON CRENSHAW, 6:00 A.M. Esther, unrecognizable in a hoodie and wraps, learning to throw a punch from a grizzled TRAINER (60s). He's never heard of HALLELUJAH HOLIDAY. He's very impressed by her right hook.

-- CORNELIUS'S STUDY, NIGHT. Esther reads the banishment speech. Cornelius doesn't stop her this time. He just listens. When she finishes, he takes off his glasses and wipes his eyes without saying anything.

-- THE KITCHEN, DINNER. Desmond and Celeste talk about a new faith-based musical script for Esther. She nods, smiles, says "That sounds lovely, Daddy." Under the table, her knuckles are bruised from the heavy bag.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - GARAGE - NIGHT

SUPER: SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 21, 2009 - 11:30 P.M. PST

The garage has been transformed. A black sheet hangs against the back wall. Two clamp lights from Home Depot. Simone stands behind a Canon camcorder on a tripod. Cornelius sits in a folding chair off to the side, his cane across his knees, watching. Everyone else in the house is asleep.

Esther stands in front of the black sheet. No costume. Black tank top, black pants, hair pulled back. In her hand, the Home Depot sledgehammer, the handle wrapped in leather from an old belt. She looks completely different. Not America's sweetheart. Someone older and harder.

SIMONE
(whispering)
Rolling. Esther Smilley. Thor, scene fourteen. Take...

(checking a notepad)
...take forty-one.

CORNELIUS
(quietly)
Breathe, baby girl. Then let them wait.

Esther closes her eyes. Breathes. Opens them. She speaks to an invisible Odin, high above her.

ESTHER (AS THOR)
You call it arrogance, Father. I call it the blood you gave me. You taught me to swing a hammer before I could speak. You raised me among warriors and told me I was born to rule. And now that I have become exactly what you made me, you would cast me out for it?

(beat, her voice dropping, raw)
Then strip my armor. Break my name. Throw me down among the mortals. But know this, All-Father: you cannot take what I am. You can only take what you gave. And everything I am, I took myself.

She lifts the hammer slowly toward the ceiling, toward Odin, toward heaven. Her arm doesn't tremble.

ESTHER (AS THOR) (CONT'D)
I will come back. And I will be worthy.

(beat, almost a whisper)
Not because you say so. Because I say so.

Silence. The hum of the clamp lights. Simone has stopped breathing behind the camera. Esther lowers the hammer slowly, and the fire leaves her face. She's just Esther again, sweaty, in a garage at midnight.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
(small)
Was that okay?

Cornelius gets up slowly, crosses the garage and takes her face in his old hands.

CORNELIUS
(his voice thick)
I played Henry the Fifth for eight weeks in Central Park in 1963. Every night, in front of two thousand people, I tried to make them believe I was a king.

(beat)
I never made a single one of them believe it the way you just made me.

Esther starts to cry. Simone turns off the camera, walks over, and wraps her arms around both of them.

SIMONE
That's the one. We're sending that one.

CUT TO:

EMAIL - MONDAY, FEBRUARY 23, 2009, 9:02 AM PST

From: Gwen Patterson (former producer, "My Two Moms," 1992-1998)

To: Sarah Finn, Sarah Halley Finn Casting

Subject: THOR self tape - please watch before you dismiss the name

Attachment: (YouSendIt link) ESTHER_SMILLEY_THOR_SC14.mov (412 MB)

Sarah, I know what you're going to think when you see the name. Please watch the tape anyway. Please watch it all the way to the end. I directed this girl's sister for six years. I've never seen anything like this. - Gwen

CUT TO:

INT. BRANAGH'S PRODUCTION OFFICE - SHEPPERTON STUDIOS - SURREY, ENGLAND - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, MARCH 6, 2009 - 10:15 P.M. GMT

A cramped office covered in Asgard concept art: towers of gold, the Bifrost bridge, a throne room carved out of a real Norwegian fjord. KENNETH BRANAGH

(48) sits in front of a laptop with a cold cup of tea. On a speakerphone: FEIGE (V.O.) in Los Angeles, and SARAH FINN (V.O.).

SARAH FINN (V.O.)
This is the last tape in the batch, Ken. I almost didn't send it. But Gwen Patterson begged, and Gwen has never begged in twenty years.

BRANAGH
Who is it?

SARAH FINN (V.O.)
Just watch it first.

Branagh clicks play. The garage. The black sheet. The clamp lights. Esther, holding a Home Depot sledgehammer with a belt for a grip.

We don't see the tape. We see Branagh's face as he watches. At first, polite interest. Then he leans forward. Then he puts down his tea. Then, very slowly, he puts a hand over his mouth.

The tape ends. Branagh doesn't move. Two full seconds of silence on the phone line.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Ken? You still there?

BRANAGH
(quietly)
Play it again, Sarah. No. I'll play it again.

He drags the slider back to the start and watches the last thirty seconds again. "Not because you say so. Because I say so."

BRANAGH (CONT'D)
Who is she?

SARAH FINN (V.O.)
Esther Smilley.

FEIGE (V.O.)
(startled)
Esther Smilley? The... the Shirley Temple girl? The nun musicals? HALLELUJAH HOLIDAY?

BRANAGH
I don't know what any of those words mean, Kevin, and I don't care. That woman just did the banishment speech in iambic pentameter better than half the actors I've worked with at the Royal Shakespeare Company. With a hammer from a hardware store.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Ken, her father is Desmond Smilley. The Smilleys and the Donohues have been at war for forty years. Our Iron Man is Victor Donohue's grandson. If we cast her, it's going to be the biggest Hollywood soap opera since...

BRANAGH
Kevin. You asked me for someone who's been told her whole life to be a good girl and is secretly a warrior.

(pointing at the frozen frame on the screen, Esther with the hammer raised)
There she is. In a garage. At midnight. Practically hiding.

A long silence on the line.

FEIGE (V.O.)
...Bring her in.

CUT TO:

INT. RALEIGH STUDIOS - REHEARSAL HALL C - HOLLYWOOD - DAY

SUPER: THURSDAY, MARCH 26, 2009 - 10:00 A.M. PDT

The same kind of fluorescent rehearsal hall where Tayia read for Pepper and Amond became the Hulk. A long table: Branagh, Feige, Sarah Finn, and LENORA HAYES (44). In the corner: a stunt coordinator, a practice mat, and a Marvel prop case.

Esther walks in wearing simple black workout clothes. No makeup. Her hair is in a tight braid. She stops in front of the table.

BRANAGH
(rising, warm)
Miss Smilley. Kenneth Branagh. I've watched your tape eleven times. My wife has started asking who the woman in the garage is.

ESTHER
(nervous, polite)
Thank you for seeing me, Mr. Branagh.

BRANAGH
Ken, please. Before we start: where do your parents think you are right now?

A beat. Esther looks him in the eye.

ESTHER
A church retreat in Palm Springs.

Lenora writes something on her pad. Feige and Branagh exchange a look.

LENORA
Miss Smilley, I'm going to be frank. Your father's company manages your career. We need to know that if we make you an offer, you can legally accept it.

ESTHER
My management contract gives Smilley Management Group a commission on my earnings. It doesn't give them the right to choose my roles. I checked.

(beat)
I have my own lawyer now. Her name is Brenda Okafor. My sister knows her from... from a meeting.

LENORA
(eyebrows raised, impressed)
Brenda Okafor is one of the toughest entertainment lawyers in Los Angeles.

ESTHER
That's what Simone said.

Branagh smiles. He gestures to the mat.

BRANAGH
First, the hammer.

The stunt coordinator opens the prop case. Inside: the same forged MJOLNIR from Comic-Con. "IF SHE BE WORTHY" catches the fluorescent light.

STUNT COORDINATOR
Fifteen pounds. Real steel core. Most people can't hold it at arm's length for more than ten seconds.

Esther looks at the hammer. Her eyes fill for a second. It's the same hammer she watched on G4 in her sister's bedroom. She wraps her hand around the leather handle and lifts it in one smooth motion. She holds it out at arm's length. Ten seconds. Twenty. Thirty. Her arm doesn't waver.

STUNT COORDINATOR (CONT'D)
(glancing at his watch, surprised)
...Okay. You can put it down.

ESTHER
I've been swinging a sledgehammer two hundred times every morning for two months.

FEIGE
(to himself)
She's been training for a part she didn't even have.

BRANAGH
(quietly, to Feige)
She's been training for it her whole life, Kevin. She just didn't know what it was called.

CUT TO:

INT. RALEIGH STUDIOS - REHEARSAL HALL C - LATER

SUPER: THURSDAY, MARCH 26, 2009 - 11:30 A.M. PDT

The door opens. TOM HIDDLESTON (28), lanky, impossibly polite, with dark hair, walks in carrying a coffee. He was cast as Loki last month.

HIDDLESTON
Hello! Tom. I'm Loki. Allegedly. I'm told I'm reading with my sister today.

ESTHER
(shaking his hand)
Esther. I'm... allegedly auditioning.

HIDDLESTON
(a twinkle)
Ken tells me you did the banishment speech in a garage with a hardware-store hammer. That's the most Shakespearean thing I've ever heard.

BRANAGH
From the throne room, please. The night before the coronation.

They take their marks facing each other. Hiddleston transforms: a sly, wounded smile. Esther transforms: shoulders back, chin up, a born ruler.

HIDDLESTON (AS LOKI)
Sister. Tomorrow you'll be queen. Everything you've ever wanted. Are you nervous?

ESTHER (AS THOR)
Nervous? I've faced frost giants. I can face a crown.

HIDDLESTON (AS LOKI)
(stepping closer)
Can you? Father's watched you swing a hammer for a thousand years. He's never once watched you listen.

ESTHER (AS THOR)
(off script, a playful edge)
And he's watched you listen for a thousand years, brother. Never once has he seen you speak the truth.

Hiddleston blinks, genuinely caught. Then a delighted grin breaks through Loki's face.

HIDDLESTON (AS LOKI)
(improvising back)
Touché, Your Majesty. Perhaps that's why he loves you more.

ESTHER (AS THOR)
(softer, real hurt, also improvised)
Is that what you believe? Loki. Look at me. I would give that crown away tomorrow if it meant you'd stop looking at me like that.

Hiddleston drops his eyes. For a moment, the room is completely silent. Two siblings who love each other and can't find their way back.

BRANAGH
(barely audible)
...Cut.

Hiddleston lets out a breath and laughs, a little shaken.

HIDDLESTON
Well. I think I just lost the argument and the crown.

Branagh turns to Feige. He doesn't say anything. He doesn't need to. Feige looks at Lenora. Lenora closes her legal pad.

LENORA
(quietly)
Her father is going to declare war.

FEIGE
He's been at war since 1966. It's just the first time he'll be at war with his own daughter.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - ESTHER'S BEDROOM - VIEW PARK - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, MARCH 26, 2009 - 11:40 P.M. PDT

Esther lies on her bed, exhausted, bruised, happy. "Back from Palm Springs." Her RAZR buzzes.

TEXT MESSAGE - "MAYOR" TO ESTHER

THU 3/26/09 11:41 PM

how was palm springs? u never told me what ur auditioning for. u ok?

TEXT MESSAGE - ESTHER TO "MAYOR"

THU 3/26/09 11:43 PM

i cant tell u. not because i dont trust u. because if i get it i need everyone in the world to know u had nothing to do with it. including u

TEXT MESSAGE - "MAYOR" TO ESTHER

THU 3/26/09 11:44 PM

that's the most esther thing anyone has ever said. ok. i wont ask. but whatever it is, they'd be crazy not to pick u

She holds the phone to her chest. For once, she doesn't delete the messages right away. She reads them three more times. Then she deletes them.

CUT TO:

INT. BRENDA OKAFOR'S LAW OFFICE - CENTURY CITY - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, MAY 1, 2009 - 3:15 P.M. PDT

A sleek high-rise office. Floor-to-ceiling windows look across the city toward Fox's Century City lot. BRENDA OKAFOR (55), a Nigerian-American entertainment lawyer with silver locs and reading glasses, sits behind her desk. Esther and Simone sit across from her. Esther's leg is bouncing.

BRENDA
You understand, once this is signed, your father will find out within a week.

ESTHER
I understand.

BRENDA
Your management contract runs through 2014. He'll still be entitled to his commission. He'll try to make your life miserable. He may try to make the press think you're ungrateful, or confused, or being manipulated.

SIMONE
Oh, he'll definitely try the "manipulated" thing. Probably blame me.

BRENDA
(dry)
Probably. You're the obvious suspect, Simone. You're twenty-two months sober and furious at him.

SIMONE
Twenty-three months.

BRENDA
My apologies.

Brenda's desk phone buzzes. Her assistant's voice: "Marvel Studios on line one. Kevin Feige and Kenneth Branagh." Brenda looks at Esther over her glasses.

BRENDA (CONT'D)
Ready?

Esther nods. She can't speak. Brenda presses the speaker button.

BRENDA (CONT'D)
Gentlemen. You have my client on the line.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Esther. It's Kevin. Ken's here too, from London.

BRANAGH (V.O.)
Hello, Your Majesty.

Esther grabs Simone's hand so hard Simone winces.

FEIGE (V.O.)
We saw four hundred and twelve actresses. We saw movie stars. We saw action heroes. We saw people who've won Oscars. And every single time we finished an audition, Ken would say, "Yes, but she's not the woman in the garage."

BRANAGH (V.O.)
I said it eleven times, I'm afraid. I became insufferable.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Esther Smilley, we'd like you to be Thor.

Silence. Esther's face crumples. She covers her mouth with both hands. Simone throws her arms around her.

ESTHER
(finally, barely audible)
Thank you. Thank you. I won't let you down. I won't let her down.

BRANAGH (V.O.)
Let who down?

ESTHER
(wiping her eyes)
Thor. She's been waiting for me for a very long time.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - CORNELIUS'S STUDY - VIEW PARK - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, MAY 1, 2009 - 9:00 P.M. PDT

Esther slips in and closes the door. Cornelius looks up from his book. She doesn't say anything. She just nods.

Cornelius sets down the book. He stands slowly, opens a drawer in his desk, and takes out a small, worn velvet box. He opens it: an old, tarnished gold pin shaped like a crown.

CORNELIUS
Joe Papp gave me this on closing night of HENRY V. 1963. He said, "For the only king in New York who earned it."

(pinning it to her sweater with trembling hands)
Now it's for the only queen in Asgard who earned it.

Esther throws her arms around her grandfather.

CORNELIUS (CONT'D)
(holding her)
They announce on Tuesday?

ESTHER
Tuesday morning.

CORNELIUS
Then you have three days to decide how to tell your father.

ESTHER
I'm not going to tell him, Granddaddy.

(pulling back, steady)
He's going to read it in VARIETY. Like everybody else.

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL ENTERTAINMENT - NEWS WIRE - DAY

SUPER: TUESDAY, MAY 5, 2009 - 6:00 A.M. PDT

MARVEL ENTERTAINMENT, INC. - PRESS RELEASE - TUESDAY, MAY 5, 2009, 6:00 AM PT

ESTHER SMILLEY TO STAR AS THOR IN MARVEL STUDIOS' "THOR"

Kenneth Branagh Directs; Film Will Shoot on Location in Norway, Iceland and New Mexico for May 6, 2011 Release

LOS ANGELES - Marvel Studios today announced that Esther Smilley will star as Thor, the God of Thunder, in THOR, directed by Kenneth Branagh. Tom Hiddleston co-stars as Loki. Smilley will perform her own stunts, including all hammer combat, on practical sets built in Norway and Iceland.

"After more than four hundred auditions, one tape stood alone," said Branagh. "Esther Smilley sent us a self-tape made in her family's garage, with a hammer from a hardware store. She performed the banishment of Thor in perfect verse, with a ferocity and grace I haven't seen since my days at the Royal Shakespeare Company. She is the daughter of Odin. She is worthy."

"Every story Stan Lee and Jack Kirby told about Thor will be on that screen at full power," said Kevin Feige. "Planets, gods, the Destroyer, Surtur. And at the center of it is the most extraordinary actress we've ever seen walk into a room."

"I created Thor in 1962," said Stan Lee. "I always said Thor was about worthiness. Esther Smilley just proved it. Verily, forsooth, and excelsior!"

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - KITCHEN - VIEW PARK - MORNING

SUPER: TUESDAY, MAY 5, 2009 - 7:15 A.M. PDT

A normal morning. CELESTE (49) makes eggs. JULIAN (32) eats cereal while reading the L.A. TIMES sports page. DESMOND (51) sits at the island opening his laptop to check the trades, as he does every morning.

Esther stands at the counter making tea. Very still. Simone sits at the table, pretending to read a magazine, watching her father.

Desmond's laptop loads VARIETY.COM. He stops. Leans closer. His coffee cup freezes halfway to his mouth.

On the screen: a large photo. Esther, in black, braid down her back, holding Mjolnir aloft. Headline: "SMILLEY IS MARVEL'S THOR."

Desmond reads it. Then reads it again. He looks up slowly. Esther is facing him, cup of tea in hand.

DESMOND
(very quiet)
What is this?

ESTHER
It's a job, Daddy.

Celeste turns from the stove. Julian lowers the sports page. The kitchen is silent except for the sizzle of eggs.

DESMOND
A "church retreat in Palm Springs."

ESTHER
I'm sorry I lied to you. I'm not sorry I went.

CELESTE
(rushing to the laptop, reading, stunned)
Thor? Esther, it's a... it's a violent movie. Battles. Monsters. That's not you, sweetheart. That's not your audience.

ESTHER
It's exactly me, Mama. It's the most me thing I've ever done.

Desmond closes the laptop. Very slowly. Very carefully. He stands.

DESMOND
Do you have any idea whose universe that is? Do you know who's in it? That family...

ESTHER
It's Stan Lee and Jack Kirby's universe, Daddy.

DESMOND
(his voice rising for the first time)
It's NATASHA BULLOCK'S son's universe! It's Victor Donohue's grandson's universe! You are going to stand next to that family on a red carpet and smile for the cameras while everything they took from us...

ESTHER
(cutting him off, quiet but unshakable)
They didn't take this from you, Daddy. I took it for me.

Silence. Desmond stares at his daughter as if he's never seen her before. In a way, he hasn't.

DESMOND
Your contract with Smilley Management runs through 2014. Every dollar you make goes through this family.

ESTHER
Then you'll get your commission. Brenda Okafor will make sure of it. But you won't get to choose for me anymore.

DESMOND
(staggered)
Brenda Okafor? You hired a lawyer? Against your own father?

His eyes swing toward Simone, who has put down her magazine.

DESMOND (CONT'D)
You. You did this. You put this in her head.

SIMONE
(standing, calm)
Somebody had to, Daddy. You put the nun in it.

DESMOND
Get out of my...

CORNELIUS (O.S.)
Desmond.

Everyone turns. Cornelius stands in the doorway, leaning on his cane, in his robe. Hattie is behind him.

CORNELIUS (CONT'D)
Leave the girls alone. Simone didn't put anything in her head. I taught her the verse. Every night for two months. In my study. She swung that hammer in your garage every morning at five-thirty while you slept.

Desmond looks at his father. The betrayal on his face is total.

DESMOND
You?

CORNELIUS
Me. And I'd do it again.

DESMOND
Daddy, they took the Fund. They took your company. They took Mama Pearl's...

CORNELIUS
(raising a trembling hand)
And I have spent forty-three years letting what they took decide everything I did. I am not going to watch it decide everything SHE does.

(beat, softer)
Your daughter just got the role of a lifetime, son. Out of four hundred women. With a hammer from Home Depot and a belt from my closet. Tell her you're proud of her. It's not too late.

A long, terrible silence. Desmond looks at Esther. Something moves behind his eyes, something that might once have been pride. He fights it down.

DESMOND
(barely audible, cold)
Is this about him?

Esther freezes for half a second.

ESTHER
This is about me.

Desmond looks at her for a long moment. Then he picks up his laptop and walks out of the kitchen without another word. A door slams somewhere in the house.

Celeste stands at the stove, the eggs burning, tears in her eyes, torn between her husband and her daughter. Julian slowly stands, walks over to Esther, and, to everyone's shock, hugs her.

JULIAN
(quietly)
Congratulations, little sister. Somebody in this family had to win one.

CUT TO:

MONTAGE - THE WORLD REACTS

SUPER: TUESDAY, MAY 5, 2009 - THROUGHOUT THE DAY

VARIETY - TUESDAY, MAY 5, 2009

SMILLEY IS MARVEL'S THOR

"Hallelujah Holiday" star beats 400+ actresses with a self-taped garage audition; Branagh calls her "the daughter of Odin." The casting puts a Smilley in a universe led by a Donohue heir, reigniting Hollywood's most famous feud.

DEADLINE HOLLYWOOD DAILY - TUESDAY, MAY 5, 2009, 7:40 AM PT

TOLDJA THIS WAS GOING TO BE A SOAP OPERA: A SMILLEY HOLDS THE HAMMER

Sources in View Park tell me Desmond Smilley found out about his daughter's casting from Variety at breakfast this morning. Not from his daughter. From VARIETY. I'm also told the Smilley patriarch, Cornelius, personally coached her Shakespeare. Let that sink in. The Smilley-Donohue war just went cosmic.

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "OFFICIAL: ESTHER SMILLEY IS THOR" (Page 1 of 478)

NoNerfsPlz (May 5, 6:08 AM)
I TOLD YOU. I TOLD YOU IT WOULD BE SOMEONE NOBODY EXPECTED. A self-tape in a GARAGE with a HOME DEPOT HAMMER. I'm screaming in my lab.

ThorOdinson4Ever (May 5, 6:15 AM)
The Hallelujah Holiday girl?? Shirley Temple is Thor?? Marvel has lost its mind. Boycott.

ShellHead1963 (May 5, 6:30 AM)
Kid Mayor. Slime kid. Now the nun girl. Marvel has done this three times and been right three times. Apology #209 is pre-written. I'm just waiting to post it.

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (May 5, 6:42 AM)
Branagh said she did the banishment speech in iambic pentameter better than RSC actors. KENNETH BRANAGH SAID THAT.

WarMachineRox (May 5, 7:01 AM)
Wait. Read Deadline. Her GRANDFATHER coached her. Cornelius Smilley. Tony winner. The guy who's been feuding with Victor Donohue since the '60s. Coached his granddaughter into the Donohue grandson's universe. This is better than the movies.

Repulsor_Ray (May 5, 7:20 AM)
So Iron Man is a Donohue and Thor is a Smilley. The Avengers is gonna be a family feud on screen. I'm buying ten tickets.

Mjolnir_Worthy (May 5, 8:15 AM)
Okay. I was against female Thor. I just watched her Comic-Con-style test footage Marvel posted. She holds the hammer out for thirty seconds without shaking. I'm... I'm reconsidering everything.

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

hallhpriya: ESTHER SMILLEY IS THOR. A WOMAN WHO GREW UP BEING TOLD TO BE A GOOD GIRL IS NOW THE GOD OF THUNDER. i'm crying in my thermodynamics class again 6:20 AM May 5th from txt

amondbaker: welcome to the team, your majesty. i told you so a year ago. hulk was right. hulk is always right 7:30 AM May 5th from web

tayiaboyd: ESTHER! the girl who sang at the 1994 kids choice awards. so proud of you 8:02 AM May 5th from web

marcanthonyb: congratulations to the new god of thunder. i had absolutely nothing to do with this and i've never been so happy to have nothing to do with something 10:12 AM May 5th from web

FACEBOOK - GROUP: "SHE IS WORTHY (MARVEL'S THOR)" - 612,488 members

Wall post - Jasmine T. (Howard University, '08): A Black woman is the God of Thunder. She trained with a sledgehammer in her garage. She learned Shakespeare from her grandfather. I am going to tell my future daughters about today.

E! NEWS - LIVE - TUESDAY, MAY 5, 2009, 7:00 PM ET

ON-SCREEN GRAPHIC: "FROM NUN TO NORSE GOD: Esther Smilley Defies Her Family to Become Thor"

CUT TO:

INT. DONOHUE ESTATE - VICTOR'S STUDY - BEL AIR - DAY

SUPER: TUESDAY, MAY 5, 2009 - 11:00 A.M. PDT

VICTOR (72) reads the Deadline article on a laptop his assistant set up for him. JOAN (71) reads over his shoulder.

JOAN
"The Smilley patriarch, Cornelius, personally coached her Shakespeare."

Victor leans back in his chair. A long silence.

VICTOR
He taught her Henry the Fifth. I'd bet my life on it. He played it in Central Park in '63. I went to every single performance. I sat in the back so he wouldn't see me.

JOAN
(softly)
You never told me that.

VICTOR
I never told anyone.

He stares at the photo of Esther holding Mjolnir.

VICTOR (CONT'D)
He let his granddaughter walk into our grandson's world, Joan. Cornelius Smilley. The proudest man I ever knew.

(beat)
Something's changed in him.

JOAN
(carefully)
Something changed in him on election night.

Victor looks at her sharply. She holds his gaze. Neither of them mentions the phone call.

CUT TO:

EXT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE - BACK PORCH - LOS FELIZ - NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, MAY 5, 2009 - 11:20 P.M. PDT

Marc-Anthony (27) sits alone on the porch steps. The city lights stretch out below. His phone is in his hand. He has been staring at it for ten minutes. He finally does something he has never done before in three years: he presses CALL instead of typing a text.

It rings. Once. Twice.

ESTHER (V.O.)
(whispering, surprised)
...Hello?

INTERCUT - ESTHER'S BEDROOM, VIEW PARK:

Esther is sitting on her closet floor in the dark, the door closed, the phone to her ear. Cornelius's crown pin is still on her sweater.

MARC-ANTHONY
Hi.

ESTHER
You've never called before.

MARC-ANTHONY
I know. I wanted to hear you say it.

ESTHER
(a small, disbelieving laugh)
Say what?

MARC-ANTHONY
That you're Thor.

A long pause. Esther closes her eyes.

ESTHER
(barely audible)
I'm Thor.

MARC-ANTHONY
I didn't know. I swear. I didn't know until I read Variety this morning, and then I had to sit down on the floor of my kitchen.

ESTHER
I know you didn't. That's the whole point.

MARC-ANTHONY
A garage, Esther. A hardware-store hammer. Your grandfather.

ESTHER
My grandfather.

(beat, her voice cracking)
My dad found out from Variety. He asked if it was about you.

Marc-Anthony goes very still.

MARC-ANTHONY
What did you say?

ESTHER
I said it was about me.

(beat)
Which was true.

MARC-ANTHONY
Mostly true?

A long, long silence on the line.

ESTHER
(very softly)
Goodnight, Marc.

MARC-ANTHONY
(smiling into the dark)
Goodnight, Your Majesty.

Click. Esther holds the phone against her chest on the closet floor. For the first time, there's nothing to delete. A phone call leaves no messages behind.

Marc-Anthony sits on the porch steps, looking at the city. He laughs to himself, quietly, then puts his face in his hands.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
(to himself)
...Mostly true.

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER EIGHT